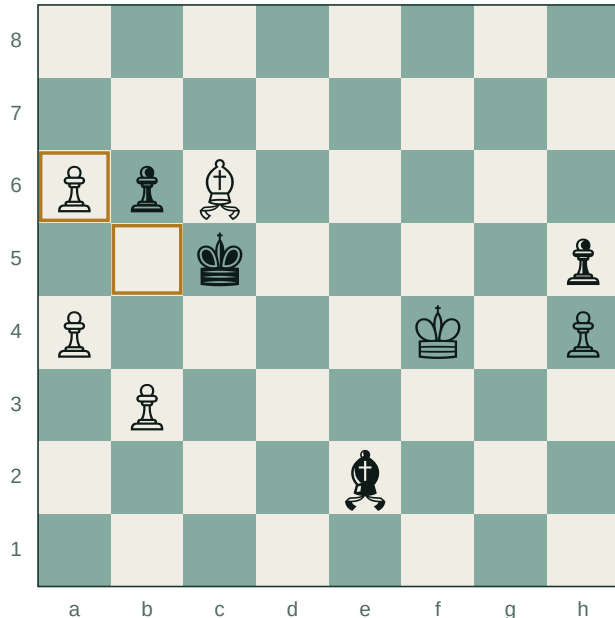


Bishop-ending decisions: Black, move 52

Bishop-ending decisions

Black to move



Previous move: 52.bxa6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

52...Kxc6 53. a7 Kb7

52...Kxc6 The king captures the bishop on c6. Recorded reply: **53.a7**.

53...Kb7 The king moves from c6 to b7.

At the end, nominal material is White 4 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from -2 to +1. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Same-colored and opposite-colored bishop endings have different tendencies, but neither label replaces calculation of the actual pawn races.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A bishop ending depends on diagonal access, pawn color, king activity, and promotion squares. Tactics can arise when a bishop must perform two defensive jobs.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace the bishop's line to each target and identify pawns that can break its coverage or force it to move.

The defending king is on f4. Geometrically undefended: bishop on c6. Check for tactical protection.